



SUPPORTING CHILDREN'S DIGITAL WELLBEING

A Practical Guide for Sri Lankan Parents

5 C's Framework • 5 M's of Digital Wellness • Age-by-Age Guide • 5 Local Case Studies • Warning Signs • Resources & Helplines

2025

For parents

For grandparents

For every device situation

International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC)

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"Every child deserves a healthy digital life."

Contents

A guide to every part of this manual, with the infographics and case studies woven throughout.

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Foreword: Why This Guide Exists

The International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) works so that every child in Sri Lanka can grow up with a healthy digital life — one where the internet, mobile phones, and social media open doors rather than expose them to harm. This guide was written for you, a Sri Lankan parent, grandparent, or caregiver, who wants practical, culturally grounded guidance rather than generic advice copied from abroad.

Two things make Sri Lanka's situation distinct from the Western contexts most parenting content is written for. First, access here is often shared rather than personal: one family phone, a grandmother's WhatsApp, a data bundle that runs out mid-month — all of this changes how 'screen time rules' actually work in practice. Second, a very large number of Sri Lankan households are separated by migration, with one or both parents working abroad and children raised by grandparents or relatives who may feel less confident navigating apps their grandchildren use fluently. This guide speaks directly to both realities.

Every insight in this guide is explained in full — not just stated as a rule — so that you understand the reasoning behind it and can adapt it sensibly to your own household, whichever language you speak at home, and whichever device situation you are managing.

How to use this guide

Read Parts 1–4 once, together with your co-parent or the elder caring for your child, to build a shared understanding.

Return to Parts 5–10 as reference material whenever a specific situation comes up.

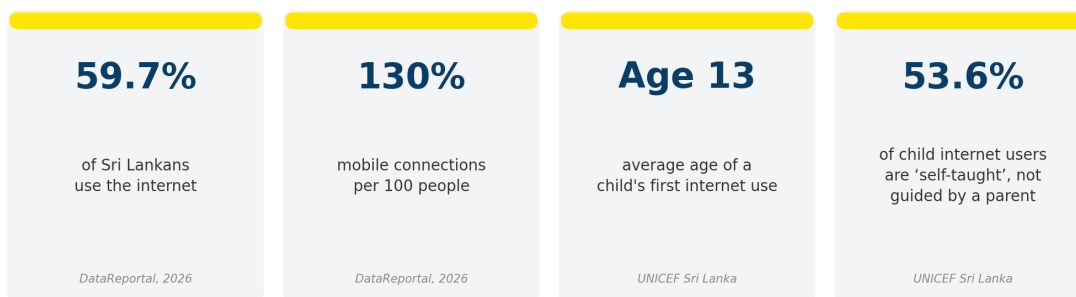
Use the checklist at the end as a working document — print it, or keep it open on your phone.

Part 1 — Understanding Sri Lanka's Digital Landscape

Before setting any rule at home, it helps to understand the environment your child is actually growing up in. The figures below, drawn from the most recent national and international research, describe that environment — and each one carries a specific implication for parents.

Sri Lanka's Digital Landscape at a Glance

Why digital wellbeing matters for Sri Lankan families



Sources: DataReportal Digital 2026: Sri Lanka | UNICEF Sri Lanka, 'Keeping Children Safe and Empowered Online'

What these numbers mean for you

- 59.7% internet penetration means more than half the country is online — but roughly 4 in 10 Sri Lankans are still offline, so families new to connectivity may be setting up their very first rules for a first-ever device. There is no shame in starting from zero.
- 130 mobile connections per 100 people does not mean everyone owns a phone. It usually means a household has several active SIM cards spread across a smaller number of shared handsets — a parent's old phone handed down to a child, or one tablet used by three siblings. Because of this, 'my child's device' is often really 'our family's device', which changes how privacy, monitoring, and screen-time rules should be designed — they need to work for the whole household, not just one child.
- Age 13 as the average age of first internet access is earlier than many parents assume, and it is an average — many children go online well before this, often through a sibling's or parent's phone rather than a device of their own.
- 53.6% of children describe themselves as 'self-taught' online, compared to only 16.5% who say a parent taught them. This is the single most important statistic in this guide: most Sri Lankan children are learning the internet by trial and error, without adult guidance, at exactly the age when judgment is still developing. Closing this gap — becoming the adult who teaches, not just supervises — is the central goal of this guide.

Sources: DataReportal, Digital 2026: Sri Lanka; UNICEF Sri Lanka, 'Keeping Children Safe and Empowered Online: A Study on Sri Lanka's Digital Landscape.'

Part 2 — Why Children's Brains Make Them Vulnerable Online

It is easy to tell a child 'just put the phone down,' but that instruction fights against how their brain is actually built. Understanding this is not an excuse for unlimited screen time — it is the reason a plan is needed at all.

The still-developing brain

The prefrontal cortex — the part of the brain responsible for impulse control, weighing consequences, and resisting short-term temptation — is one of the last regions to mature, continuing to develop into a person's mid-twenties. A 10-year-old or a 15-year-old is not being lazy or defiant when they struggle to stop playing a game or scrolling a feed; their brain's 'braking system' genuinely is not fully installed yet. This is a universal, biological fact, not a Sri Lankan or Western cultural trait — which is why patience paired with clear structure works better than shame or lectures.

Apps are engineered to be hard to put down

This is the part parents are often not told plainly: popular apps among Sri Lankan children — TikTok, YouTube Shorts, Free Fire, PUBG Mobile, Instagram Reels — are built by large teams whose job is to maximise the time a person spends on the app, because more time means more advertising revenue. They use a technique from behavioural psychology called a 'variable reward' — the same mechanism that makes a slot machine compelling. You don't know if the next video will be boring or hilarious, if the next game round will be a win or a loss, or if the next scroll will bring a message from a friend. That unpredictability is what keeps a thumb moving, and it works on adults too, not just children — which is why 'just use more willpower' rarely succeeds on its own.

What this means practically

- Blame the design, not just the child. Framing it this way ("this app is built to be hard to stop, so let's build a plan together") tends to lower defensiveness and increase cooperation compared to "you have no self-control."
- Environmental changes (device out of the bedroom, app time limits set at the device level) are more reliable than willpower alone, for the same reason a person trying to eat less sugar keeps less sugar in the house.

- This is exactly why Part 3's framework focuses on structure and conversation, not on lecturing your child to simply try harder.

Part 3 — The 5 C's Framework

In 2026, the American Academy of Pediatrics (AAP) — the leading US professional body for child health — moved away from a simple hours-per-day rule (previously 'two hours a day') toward a framework of five questions to ask about any child's media use. Sri Lankan pediatric and psychological practice draws heavily on this same evidence base, and it translates well locally because it focuses on function, not just duration.

The 5 C's Framework

American Academy of Pediatrics (2026) — questions to ask instead of counting hours



Source: American Academy of Pediatrics, Digital Media Guidance (2026 policy statement)

Explaining each 'C' in plain terms

- **Child** — Your own child's age, temperament, and needs matter more than any blanket national rule. An anxious 9-year-old and a confident 9-year-old may need different approaches to the same game.
- **Content** — Ask what they are actually engaging with, not just how long. A cricket highlights channel and an algorithm-fed stream of unrelated short videos are both 'screen time,' but they are not equivalent.
- **Calm** — Watch whether the device is being used to self-soothe every difficult emotion — handed over automatically whenever a child is bored, upset, or having a tantrum. Occasional use this way is normal; when it becomes the only coping tool, a child does not get the chance to develop their own emotional regulation.
- **Crowding Out** — The most important, and most concrete, question: what is this screen time replacing? If it is replacing boredom, that is low-stakes. If it is regularly replacing sleep, homework, meals, or time with friends and family, that is the signal to intervene.

- **Communication** — Is there an open, ongoing conversation about what your child does online? Families where a child feels safe telling a parent “something strange happened online today” without fear of the phone being confiscated on the spot see far better outcomes when real problems (like the case studies in Part 8) occur.

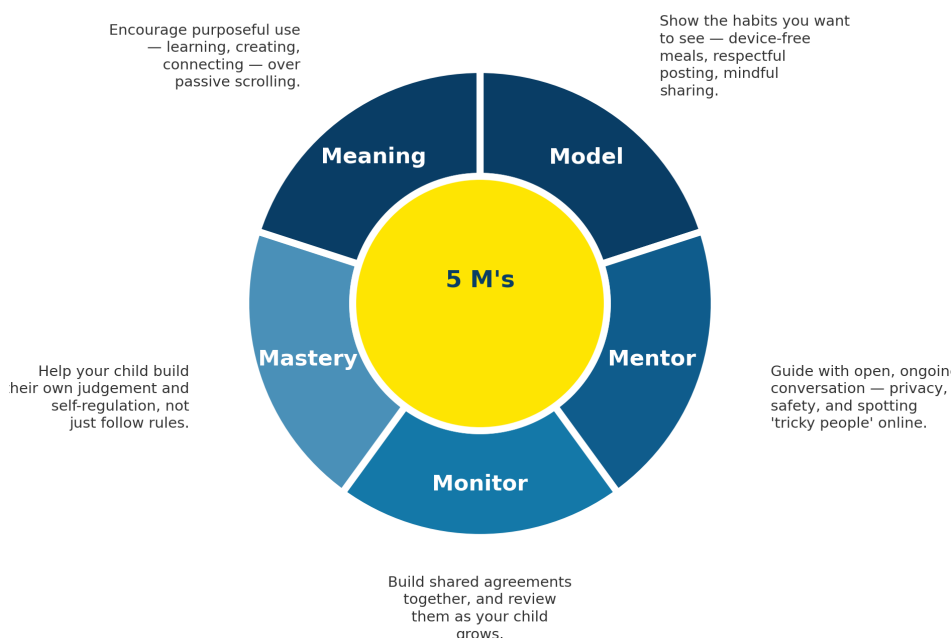
Source: American Academy of Pediatrics, Digital Media Guidance, 2026 policy statement and technical report.

Part 4 — The 5 M's of Digital Wellness

Where the 5 C's help you ask the right questions, the 5 M's — developed by the Digital Wellness Lab at Boston Children's Hospital — give you five practical roles to play as a parent, from your child's very first device onward. The comparison the Lab uses is a good one: we wouldn't hand a child a power tool without first teaching them to use it safely, and a smartphone deserves the same approach.

The 5 M's of Digital Wellness

A practical framework for building healthy family habits, adapted for Sri Lanka



Adapted from the Digital Wellness Lab, Boston Children's Hospital — '5 M's of Digital Wellness'

1. Model — show the habits you want to see

Children absorb far more from watching a parent's device habits than from being told rules. Two habits are worth building deliberately in a Sri Lankan household: keeping meals and bedrooms device-free (easier said than done when the family WhatsApp group is also how school announcements and relatives abroad reach you — consider a fixed 'checking window' instead of leaving notifications on throughout dinner), and pausing before posting photos of your children on Facebook or Instagram, which is extremely common practice here. Ask yourself why you're sharing a particular photo and what it's for, and where possible, ask your child's permission first once they're old enough to have an opinion — and respect it if they'd rather a photo came down.

2. Mentor — advise and guide, don't just supervise

Start talking about privacy, kindness, and online safety long before your child has their own phone — the same way you'd talk about road safety before they cross a street alone. Once they do have accounts, ask them to show you how privacy settings, blocking, and reporting work on their favourite apps; letting them teach you is often a better entry point than a lecture. Use plain, concrete language to describe 'tricky people' online: someone who asks your child to keep a secret, asks for personal details, makes them uncomfortable, or pressures them to lie — language a 9- or 10-year-old can actually recognise in the moment. And make sure your child can name at least one trusted adult besides you they could go to — especially important in Sri Lankan families where a parent may be working abroad and a grandparent, aunt, or teacher is the adult actually present day to day.

3. Monitor — build agreements together, and keep them current

A shared media agreement works best when your child helps write it, even if you remain the final decision-maker. For younger children, requiring login access to social media or gaming accounts as a condition of having them at all is a reasonable, common practice — and logging in together occasionally, rather than only checking in secret, keeps it collaborative rather than adversarial. Revisit the agreement when circumstances change: when a school term gives way to April, August, or December holidays and the structure of homework and tuition disappears, many families find screen use quietly expands unless the agreement is deliberately reset for the break. If you're ever genuinely worried about how your child's media use is affecting their mood, sleep, or schoolwork, treat that as worth raising with a pediatrician or school counsellor, the same as any other health concern.

4. Mastery — build independence, not just compliance

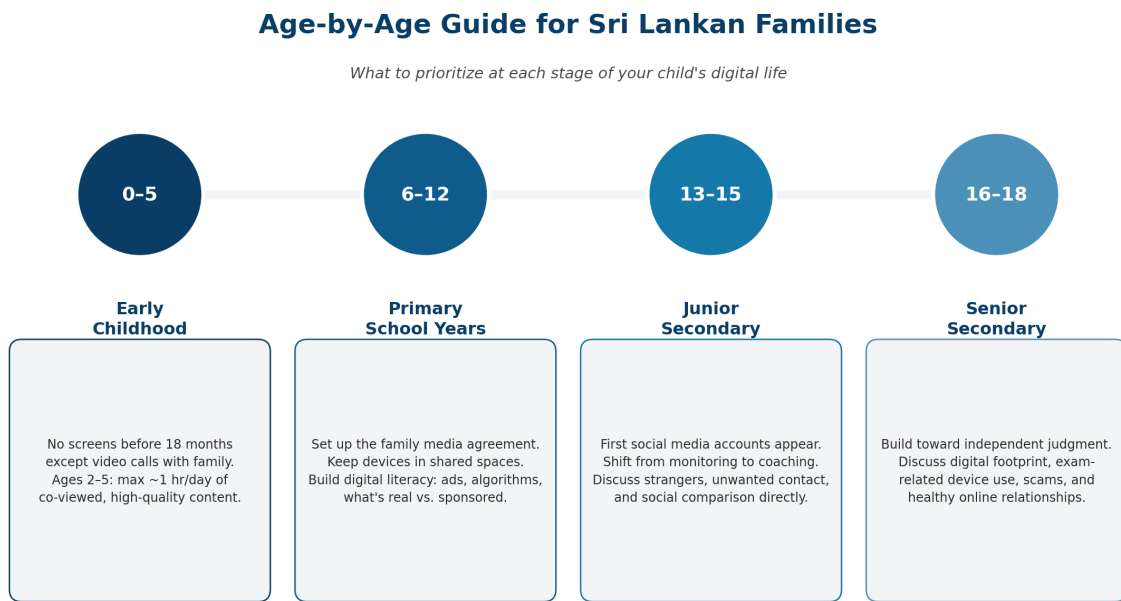
The long-term goal is a child who can regulate their own use, not one who only behaves within sight of a parent. Ask your child directly how they'd like to spend their free time, online and off, and involve them in that planning rather than dictating it. Build a simple, agreed 'what do I do if I see something upsetting online' plan together, so they have a rehearsed response rather than a panicked one in the moment. And use everyday screen situations to practise the same self-regulation skills useful for O/L and A/L study — planning ahead, resisting distraction, knowing when to stop — since these are the same underlying skills either way.

5. Meaning — encourage purposeful, not just passive, use

Rather than framing every conversation around limiting screen time, help your child move toward digital media that has a genuine purpose: educational apps and well-made documentaries over algorithm-fed short video; creating something — basic coding, digital art, video editing — rather than only consuming; using video calls to maintain real relationships, which matters enormously for the many Sri Lankan families with relatives working abroad; and pairing screen use with movement where possible, whether that's a dance or fitness app or simply treating screen time as something that happens after, not instead of, time outdoors.

Adapted from the Digital Wellness Lab, Boston Children's Hospital, 'The 5 M's of Digital Wellness' (2023), contextualised for Sri Lankan families by IFDC.

Part 5 — Age-by-Age Guidance for Sri Lankan Families



Adapted from AAP (2026) Digital Media Guidance and WHO early-childhood screen-time guidance for the Sri Lankan context

Ages 0–5 — Early childhood

Avoid screens entirely before 18 months, other than video calls with family — a genuinely important exception in Sri Lanka, where a parent working in the Middle East or elsewhere may only be able to ‘see’ their toddler through a video call. From age 2 to 5, aim for around one hour a day of high-quality, ideally co-viewed content (Sinhala- or Tamil-language children's programming, where available, supports language development better than passive exposure to unfamiliar-language content).

Ages 6–12 — Primary school years

This is the window in which most Sri Lankan children receive their first personal or shared device, often for online tuition classes or a school WhatsApp group. Use this milestone as the moment to set up a family media agreement (Part 7), before habits form rather than after. Keep devices in shared living spaces rather than bedrooms, and be aware that WhatsApp groups set up for legitimate schoolwork can also become a channel for bullying — worth a light-touch check-in, not surveillance.

Ages 13–15 — Junior secondary

Social media typically enters the picture here, often via an older sibling's account or a friend's invitation before a child has one of their own. This is also prime O/L examination pressure territory: many families see a spike in phone use for 'studying' that is, in practice, mixed with entertainment apps open in another tab. Rather than only restricting, help your teen build their own study-and-break structure, and have direct, calm conversations about unwanted contact from strangers, since this is precisely the age band where the national data on stranger contact (Part 6) is highest.

Ages 16–18 — Senior secondary

With A/L exams, university applications, and part-time or informal work often entering the picture, focus shifts to long-term digital footprint (what a future employer or university might find), recognising financial and job scams targeting teens and young adults (a growing problem in Sri Lanka, discussed in Part 11), and supporting healthy boundaries in online romantic or social relationships.

A note for grandparent and relative caregivers

If you are raising a grandchild while their parents work abroad, you do not need to become a technology expert overnight.

Focus on the relationship, not the app: ask your grandchild to show you what they use and explain it to you — this alone builds the open communication that matters most.

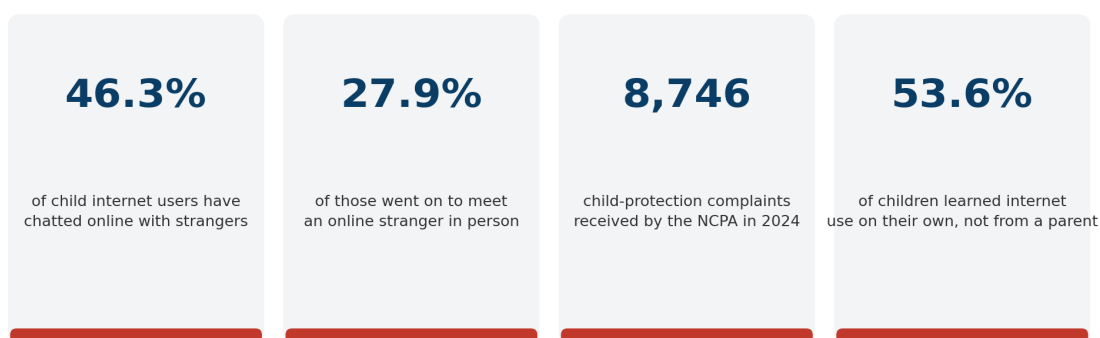
Agree with the parents abroad, over a video call, on a shared, consistent set of rules so the child does not receive different messages from different adults.

Part 6 — The Local Risk Landscape: What the Data Shows

Global advice is useful, but Sri Lankan families deserve to know what is actually happening to children in this country. The figures below come from a national UNICEF study of Sri Lankan adolescents and from the National Child Protection Authority (NCPA).

Why Online Safety Needs Attention in Sri Lanka

Local data behind this guide's recommendations



Sources: UNICEF Sri Lanka, 'Keeping Children Safe and Empowered Online' (national adolescent survey) | National Child Protection Authority, 2024 complaints data

Explaining what these figures actually mean

- 46.3% have chatted with strangers online — this includes harmless situations (an online classmate from a study group, a gaming teammate) as well as riskier ones. The concern is not chatting with any unknown person, but doing so without any adult awareness, which the next figure addresses.
- 27.9% went on to meet that online stranger in person, and worryingly, close to one in five of those meetings happened without telling anyone. This is the specific behaviour worth addressing directly with your child: not 'never talk to anyone online,' which is unrealistic and rarely followed, but 'if you ever want to meet someone you only know from online, it happens with an adult's knowledge, full stop.'
- 8,746 child-protection complaints were received by the NCPA in a single year (2024), which included hundreds of cases of grave digital sexual abuse. This is not meant to frighten you — it is meant to show that this is a real, active, national-scale issue, not a rare or foreign problem, and that the systems in Part 13 (reporting, helplines) exist because they are needed.
- 53.6% self-taught, repeated from Part 1, is the throughline connecting all of this data: children navigating real risks largely without adult guidance. Every practice in Part 7 exists to close that specific gap.

This section deliberately avoids naming or describing specific tactics used to contact or manipulate children online. If you are ever concerned about a specific message, contact, or app behaviour involving your child, the resources in Part 13 can advise you directly rather than relying on general information.

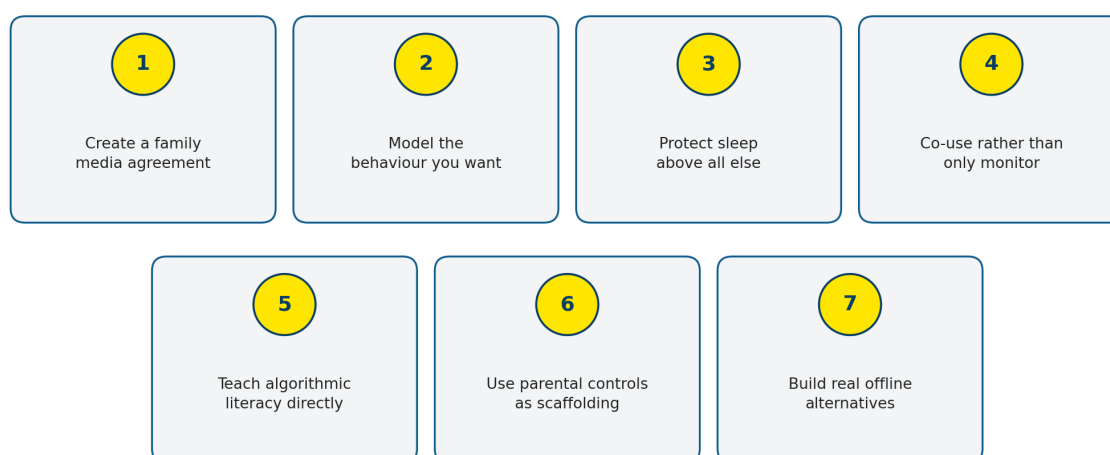
Sources: UNICEF Sri Lanka national adolescent survey, 'Keeping Children Safe and Empowered Online'; National Child Protection Authority, 2024 complaints data.

Part 7 — Best Practices, Explained

Each practice below includes the reasoning behind it — not just the instruction — so you can adapt it sensibly to your household.

7 Best Practices at a Glance

Explained in full over the following pages



1. Create a family media agreement

A written agreement (even a simple one-page note stuck to the fridge, in Sinhala, Tamil, or English) works better than rules made up in the heat of an argument, because it is decided calmly, in advance, and with everyone's input. Include device-free times (meals, the hour before bed), device-free zones (bedrooms overnight), and what happens if it is broken — agreed in advance, so a consequence feels fair rather than arbitrary. Revisit it every 6–12 months, since a rule that suits a 9-year-old will not suit them at 12.

2. Model the behaviour you want

Children copy what a parent does with their own phone far more than they follow what a parent says about phones. If dinner conversation regularly competes with a parent's phone notifications, a rule about a child's screen time will feel hollow. Narrating your own habits out loud (“I'm putting my phone in the other room now, dinner time”) teaches by example, not lecture.

3. Protect sleep above all else

Sleep is the single most reliably damaged habit when screen use is unmanaged, and poor sleep affects everything else — mood, exam performance, and even appetite. The practical fix: no screens for 60 minutes before bed, and charge devices outside the bedroom overnight, including, ideally, the parents' own phones.

4. Co-use rather than only monitor

For younger children, sitting beside them while they use an app teaches more than any monitoring software ever will. For teenagers, ask them to show you an app they enjoy rather than only checking their history in secret — asking builds trust that keeps communication open; secretly checking, if later discovered, tends to close it.

5. Teach algorithmic literacy directly

Many Sri Lankan children have never been told, in plain language, that the videos and posts they see are chosen by a computer program trying to keep them watching as long as possible, and that 'trending' does not mean 'true' or 'important.' A five-minute conversation explaining this — “why do you think the app showed you that video?” — does more for long-term critical thinking than any filter.

6. Use parental controls as scaffolding, not a permanent fix

Built-in device controls (Google Family Link, Apple Screen Time), and filtering options offered by Sri Lankan mobile operators, are genuinely useful, especially for younger children. Treat them as training wheels: the goal is to loosen them gradually as your child demonstrates good judgment, so that by their late teens they can manage their own use — a skill they will need the moment they leave home for university or work.

7. Build real offline alternatives

Children reach for a screen most often when they are bored, lonely, or anxious, so the most effective 'screen time reduction' strategy is often not a restriction at all — it is making sure something else appealing is genuinely available: cricket or netball in the evening, a temple, kovil, church, or mosque youth programme, music or dance classes, or simply unstructured time with cousins and neighbours, which is still more common in Sri Lankan communities than in many Western settings and is worth protecting deliberately.

Part 8 — Case Studies from Sri Lankan Families

The following are composite, illustrative scenarios reflecting patterns commonly seen in Sri Lankan households — not real individuals.

5 Case Studies from Sri Lankan Families



Case Study 1 — The Exam-Season TikTok Spiral (Age 15, Kandy)

Situation: With O/L examinations approaching, Nimali's parents gave her a phone to join her class's WhatsApp study group and access YouTube lessons. Within weeks, her 'study time' had quietly become mostly TikTok, and her sleep and mock-exam results both declined.

What worked: Rather than confiscating the phone outright — which risked cutting her off from the legitimate study group — her parents moved the household charging point to the kitchen for every device, including their

own, and agreed a fixed study block using a separate basic device with no app access for the YouTube lessons. Within a month, both her sleep and her mock results recovered.

Takeaway: Removing temptation from the environment works better than relying on willpower alone, and a rule that also visibly applies to the parents is far more likely to be accepted without resentment.

Case Study 2 — Comparison and Self-Esteem on Instagram (Age 14, Colombo)

Situation: Sanduni began comparing her appearance to fitness and beauty influencers she followed, and started asking for skin-lightening and beauty products beyond her age, alongside a noticeable dip in confidence.

What worked: Her mother didn't ban the app, which risked pushing the behaviour underground. Instead, they sat down together and reviewed who Sanduni followed, discussing which accounts left her feeling worse and unfollowing them, while adding accounts related to her real interests — badminton and baking. They also talked openly about sponsored content and photo editing.

Takeaway: Curating *what* is seen, combined with ongoing, low-pressure conversation, tends to work better long-term than an outright ban that a determined teenager can usually work around.

Case Study 3 — The Class WhatsApp Group Turns Hostile (Age 12, Negombo)

Situation: A school WhatsApp group set up for homework reminders became a space where a small group of classmates began mocking one student, Ruwan, who did not tell his parents for several weeks out of fear his phone privileges would be removed.

What worked: When Ruwan finally told his father, his father's first response was calm support, not immediate restriction. Together they screenshotted the messages, reported them to the class teacher and the group admin, and Ruwan's father contacted the other parents directly and respectfully rather than escalating publicly.

Takeaway: If a child's first experience of disclosing a problem is having their device taken away, they learn not to disclose the next one. Support first; address the device or app afterward, separately.

Case Study 4 — Unsupervised Gaming While Parents Work Abroad (Age 11, Kurunegala)

Situation: With both parents working in the Middle East and a grandmother as primary caregiver, Tharindu spent most evenings gaming online with older, unknown players, since his grandmother did not feel confident setting any limits on an app she did not understand.

What worked: During a weekend video call, the family agreed together — grandmother, both parents, and Tharindu — on a simple shared rule: gaming only with known school friends, in a shared room, with a clear stop time each evening, using the game's own built-in parental control settings, which his mother set up remotely during the call.

Takeaway: When a caregiver feels out of their depth with technology, the answer is not to give up on rules — it's to bring in another trusted adult (even remotely) and to lean on the app's own built-in safety tools rather than needing deep technical expertise.

Case Study 5 — Contact from a Stranger (Age 13, Galle)

Situation: Dilki began chatting with someone she believed to be a similarly aged student from another school, who gradually asked her to keep their conversation private from her parents — a pattern reflected in the national data in Part 6.

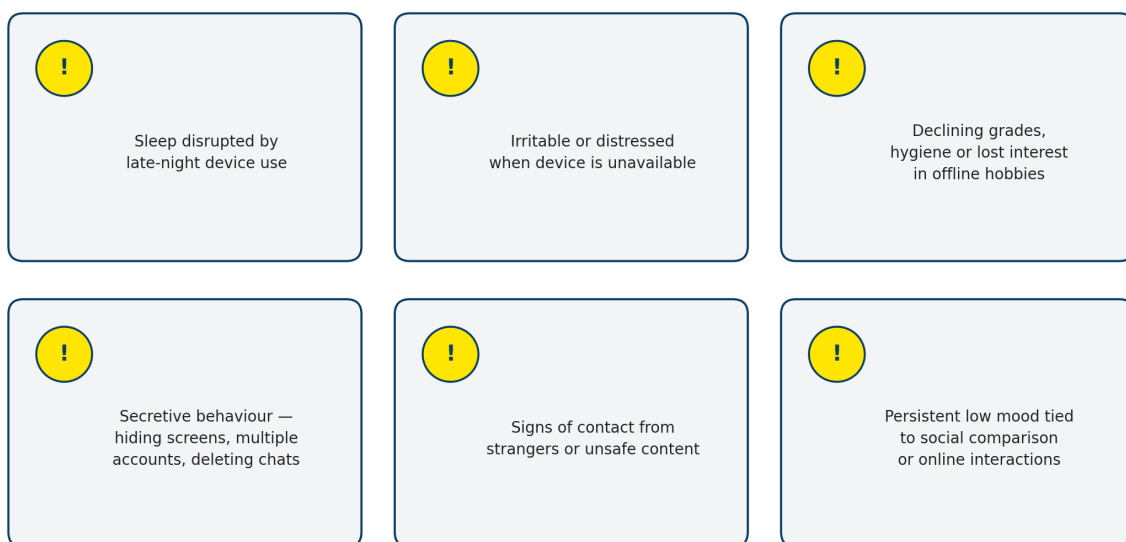
What worked: Dilki had been told, well before this happened, that being asked to keep an online friendship secret from a parent was itself a warning sign worth raising — regardless of how the conversation felt. She told her mother, who did not panic or blame her, blocked and reported the account, and contacted the NCPA helpline (1929) for guidance.

Takeaway: The single most protective thing a parent can do is establish, in advance and without drama, that being asked to keep an online relationship secret is always worth telling a trusted adult about — and that doing so will be met with support, not punishment.

Part 9 — Recognising Warning Signs

Warning Signs Worth a Closer Look

One sign alone isn't a crisis — look for patterns and changes from your child's normal baseline



If these patterns persist, consider speaking with a pediatrician, school counsellor, or child psychologist.

Why each sign matters

- Sleep disruption often shows up first, because it's the easiest routine for a device to quietly displace — and poor sleep then worsens mood, concentration, and school performance.
- Irritability or distress when a device is unavailable can indicate the app has become a primary coping mechanism, per the 'Calm' question in the 5 C's framework.
- Declining grades or lost interest in previously loved activities suggests screen use may be crowding out things that matter, not just filling free time.
- Secretive behaviour — hiding a screen when you walk in, multiple accounts, deleting messages defensively — is worth a calm, curious conversation rather than a confrontation, since confrontation tends to increase secrecy rather than reduce it.
- Signs of contact from strangers or exposure to distressing content should prompt a direct, supportive conversation and, where needed, use of the reporting resources in Part 13.
- Persistent low mood connected to social comparison or online interactions deserves attention — not necessarily alarm, but a conversation, and support from a school counsellor or professional if it continues.

A single sign, on its own, is rarely cause for alarm — children have off days for many reasons. Look for a pattern, and for a change from your own child's normal baseline, which only you are in a position to notice.

Part 10 — Talking With Your Child

How a conversation opens usually determines how it goes. A few practical shifts in language make a real difference:

Talking With Your Child: Instead Of / Try

Small language shifts that keep the conversation open

INSTEAD OF

TRY

"Why are you always on that thing?"	→	"What do you like about that app?"
"You have no self-control."	→	"This pattern isn't working for you — let's fix it together."
One big annual 'screen talk'	→	Small, frequent chats — five minutes in the car
Confiscate the phone on disclosure	→	Support first, address the device separately

- Normalise imperfection: acknowledge that even adults struggle to put their phones down sometimes — this makes the conversation feel like teamwork, not a lecture.
- If your household speaks Sinhala or Tamil at home, have these conversations in that language — discussing feelings and boundaries in a family's most natural language is usually more effective than doing so in English simply because the content (apps, internet) feels foreign.

A cultural note

In many Sri Lankan households, children are raised to not question adult authority directly, which can make open, back-and-forth conversation about phones feel unfamiliar at first.

You do not need to abandon respect for elders to build this kind of dialogue — simply setting aside a specific, calm time to ask your child's honest opinion, and genuinely listening to it, is usually enough to open the door.

Part 11 — Special Topics for Sri Lankan Families

Five Special Topics for Sri Lankan Families

AI Chatbots	In-App Purchases	Scams	Digital Footprint	Long-Distance Parenting
Not a substitute for human support	Loot boxes mimic gambling mechanics	OTPs and 'easy money' job offers	What's posted can resurface later	Structured video calls, not 'screen time'

AI chatbots and companion apps

AI chat companions are a newer category worth a specific conversation with older children and teens: these apps can feel emotionally responsive, but they are not a substitute for human relationships, and should never be relied on for medical, safety, or crisis situations. Encourage your teen to bring real emotional struggles to a trusted person, not an app.

In-app purchases and gambling-like game mechanics

Many popular games among Sri Lankan children (including battle-royale and card-collection style games) include 'loot boxes' or randomised in-game purchases that mimic gambling mechanics — paying real money for a random, uncertain reward. Disable in-app purchases at the device or account level, and treat a child asking to 'top up' game credits as worth a conversation about how these mechanics are designed to encourage repeat spending.

Financial and job scams targeting teens

Sri Lanka has seen a rise in scams specifically targeting young people — fake job or 'easy money' offers, requests for One-Time-Passwords (OTPs) or bank details, and fraudulent online shopping deals. Teach your teen, plainly: a legitimate opportunity never asks for an OTP, a bank PIN, or upfront payment to 'unlock' an opportunity or prize.

Digital footprint and university or job applications

Content posted years earlier can resurface later — through screenshots, data breaches, or simple searches — and increasingly matters for university admissions and job applications in Sri Lanka too. A simple test to teach older teens: would you be comfortable with this post on a public noticeboard at your school, with your name on it, in five years' time?

Long-distance parenting through video calls

For the many Sri Lankan families with a parent working abroad, video calls are a lifeline, not 'screen time' to be limited — but they work best with some structure: a predictable, expected time each day or week, ideally without other devices competing for the child's attention during that call, so it functions as real connection rather than background noise.

Part 12 — Global and Local Literature at a Glance

This guide draws on both international research and Sri Lanka-specific data. The table below summarises the key sources referenced throughout.

Source	Headline finding	Relevance
American Academy of Pediatrics (2026)	Moved from a fixed hours-per-day rule to the '5 C's' — Child, Content, Calm, Crowding Out, Communication.	Basis for Part 3 of this guide.
World Health Organization	Recommends no screen exposure for infants under 1 year, and limited, high-quality, supervised use for children aged 2–4.	Basis for early-childhood guidance in Part 5.
UNICEF (global, 2024)	Over 70% of young people worldwide are online, and cyberbullying prevalence in high-income countries ranges roughly 5–21%.	Context for Part 9, warning signs.
UNICEF Sri Lanka national study	53.6% of Sri Lankan children are self-taught online; 46.3% have chatted with strangers online.	Basis for Parts 1 and 5 of this guide.
National Child Protection Authority, Sri Lanka (2024)	8,746 child-protection complaints received nationally in one year, including digital sexual abuse cases.	Basis for Part 6 and the resources in Part 13.

Source	Headline finding	Relevance
UNICEF / UNESCO bullying prevalence study, Sri Lanka	47% of surveyed children experienced at least one form of bullying in a typical month; cyberbullying specifically affects a smaller, likely under-reported share.	Context for Part 9 and Part 10.

Part 13 — Resources and Helplines (Sri Lanka)

Keep this page accessible — photograph it, or pin it near the family charging station.

Service	Number / Contact	Use for
NCPA Childline (National Child Protection Authority)	1929 (free, 24/7, Sinhala/Tamil/English)	Reporting child abuse, exploitation, or online harm involving a child.
Sri Lanka Police Emergency	119	Immediate danger or a crime in progress.
Sri Lanka CERT (cyber incidents)	101	Reporting hacking, scams, or cybersecurity incidents.
National Mental Health Helpline	1926 (24/7, call or SMS)	Emotional distress, anxiety, or crisis support for any family member.
Sumithrayo	011 269 6666 / 011 269 2909	Confidential emotional support, including for young people.
IFDC — International Foundation for Digital Child	info@ifdchild.org +94 11 288 6627	Guidance, training, and advocacy on children's digital wellbeing.

Part 14 — Quick-Reference Checklist

- ☐ Family media agreement created together and revisited every 6–12 months
- ☐ Charging station outside bedrooms overnight (including parents' devices)
- ☐ Screen-free zones and times agreed (meals, before bed)
- ☐ Age-appropriate parental controls set, with a plan to loosen them over time
- ☐ Regular, low-pressure conversations happening about online experiences
- ☐ A calm, agreed plan in place for if your child discloses a problem online
- ☐ Offline activities and interests actively supported and scheduled
- ☐ Your own screen habits modelled intentionally
- ☐ Key helpline numbers (1929, 119, 101, 1926) saved in your phone
- ☐ Long-distance parenting video calls scheduled and protected from distraction

Closing Message from IFDC

There is no single 'right' amount of screen time that fits every child, every family, or every household arrangement across Sri Lanka. What the research — both global and local — consistently shows is that the

strongest protective factor is not a rule at all. It is a relationship in which your child feels safe coming to you the moment something online goes wrong.



Thank You

Every child deserves to grow up with a healthy digital life — curious, connected, and safe. This guide exists because that takes a whole family working together, not just a set of rules handed down.

Rules, structure, and the practices in this guide all matter. But they work because they are built on relationship, not instead of it. Thank you for taking the time to read this guide, and for the care that brought you to it.

“Every child deserves a healthy digital life.”

International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC)

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IFDC — Supporting Children's Digital Wellbeing, 2025